whose past achievements are a source of immense pride and even cause for a sense of superiority. Inspired by the concept of the eternal cycle of life, Indians remain confident that their tomorrow will be as good as their yesterday, if not better, and the Indian republic reflects the glory of past dynasties and empires. India's interaction with the rest of the world has almost always been informed by this civilizational sense of India's self.

Indians take pride in the ability of their culture to subsume others' lifestyles, including those of invaders and conquerors. There is a timelessness to what constitutes being Indian. Outsiders come to India and end up staying, adopting Indian culture while Indian culture adapts to external influences. The history of the empires in India, some indigenous and others initiated by foreigners, is telling. Even when the ruling dynasty comprised non-Indians, the empire in India retained a uniquely Indian quality. Thus, the Mughals may have been Turkic but their empire was very much Indian and British rule in India did not escape an Indian stamp. This simple historic fact has led to a firm belief in the absorptive capacity of Indian culture and civilization. In Indian thinking, India is too big to be taken over by others; instead, others end up being Indianized.

Among India's occupiers, the British were perhaps the least willing to go completely native. They maintained a separateness that the Aryans, Scytho-Parthians, Greeks, Mongols, Turks and Afghans did not. Even then, instead of diminishing India's sense of self, British colonial rule only helped create a framework of institutions that enabled India to grow beyond its self-imposed isolation. The Indian independence struggle gave Indians a platform to restore India's glorious past while building an independent future.

Before the advent of Western colonial powers, Indian empires asserted a civilizational sphere of influence from the Persian Gulf to South-East Asia. Geography also played a significant role in emphasizing and defining the importance of India's land and sea borders. Indian empires often